

"Mycology is queer insofar as it is marginal, subordinate, contested, ridiculed, but more critically, mycology is queer insofar as it is disruptive, collective, transformative, revolutionary"⁶

Introduction

Mycology naturally and necessarily challenges conventional species definitions and paradigms of taxonomic classification while simultaneously disrupting normative assumptions on sex, mating and even individuality.⁴ Queer Ecology, with its emphasis on the interconnectedness of all organisms, provides a particularly useful lens for the study of Fungi. Their conjunction, Queer Mycology, provides a powerful framework for reciprocally deconstructing normative assumptions that constrain our understandings of both nature and culture.⁶

Sex in Fungi

Mycology, the study of the fungal (Queen/King)dom, calls into question the primacy of heterosexual reproduction, vertical inheritance and rigid definitions of individuality & identity.

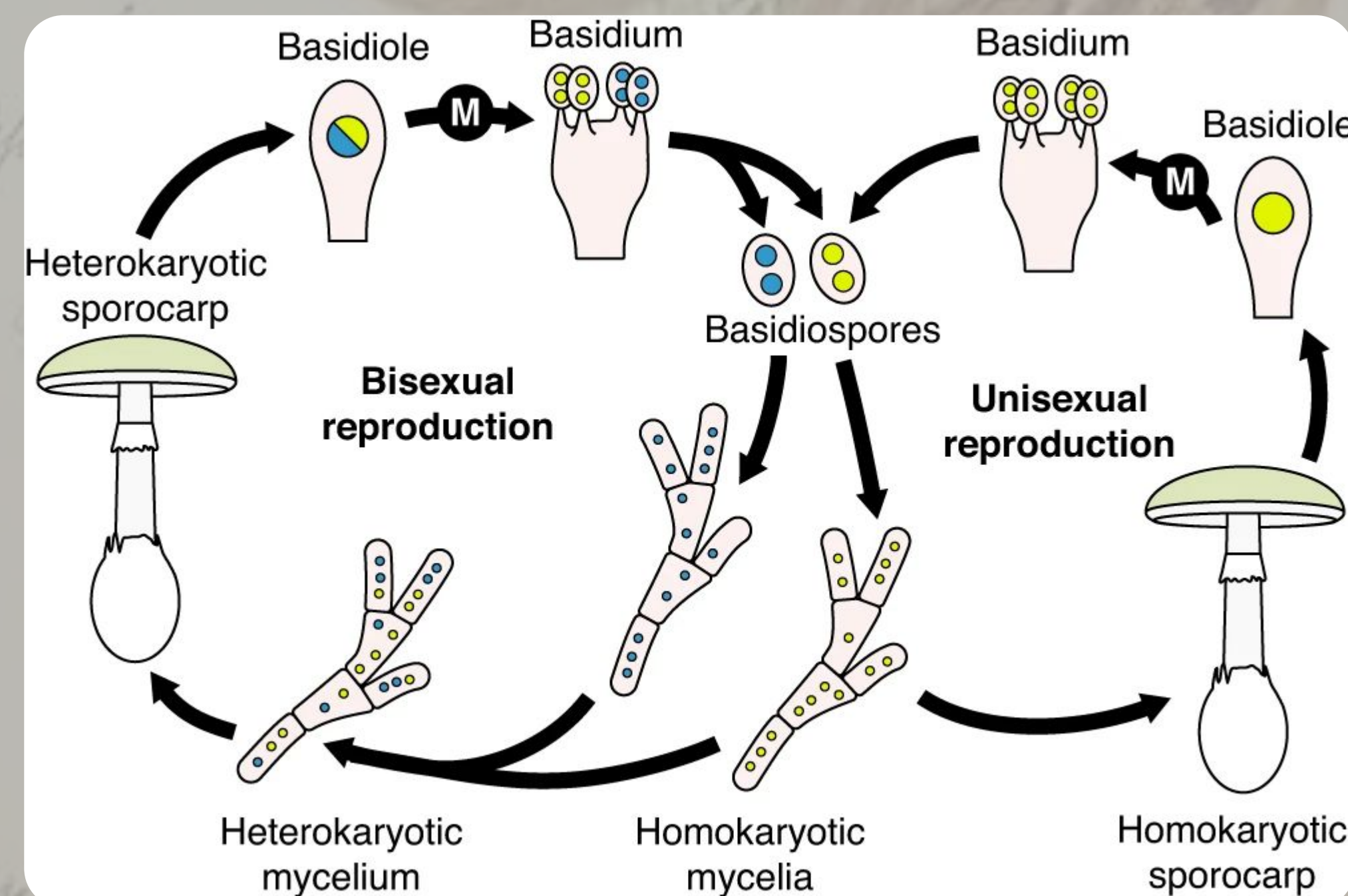
Sexual reproduction in fungi is notoriously complex. While some species reproduce only asexually, sexually reproducing fungi employ a wide variety of strategies with the majority of fungi utilizing both sexual & asexual mechanisms during different phases of their life cycles.³

Heterothallism: Reproduction with two compatible partners, with some fungi expressing 23,000+ distinct sexes (mating types) as in *Schizophyllum commune*

Mating Type Loci: Sections of the fungal genome that determine mating compatibility (may be bipolar or tetrapolar)

Homothallism: Self-fertilization via the production of cells with different mating types on the same thallus (body) via mating type switching as in *Saccharomyces cerevisiae* (Brewer's yeast)

Pseudohomothallism: Two nuclei of opposite mating types are packaged in the same spore as in *Podospira anserina*



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Biopolitics

Culturally, heteronormative political discourses appeal to what is deemed 'natural' to preserve and justify the status quo of human sociality & sexuality. These narratives advantage some bodies, behaviors and communities on the basis that they are "natural" to the detriment of those labeled "unnatural".⁷

The power to define what is "natural" carries biopolitical implications in how (un)healthy bodies are conceived of, considered and cared for. Further, heteronormativity biases research programmes and undermines rigorous investigation of the full diversity of biological reproduction.

Conclusion

Fungi sexuality fundamentally challenges heteronormative cultural narratives and motivates a Queer approach to Mycology.

References

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